Ecology, Morality, and the Challenges of the Twenty-First Century: The Earth in the Hands of the Sons of Noah

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Environmental Ethics: Ambiguities Concerning What Is at Stake

Orthodox Christianity can tell us about how to go to heaven but not how the heavens go. The Church does not possess special sensible, empirical, scientific knowledge (although this can be the case in the instance of great ascetics, true theologians) that can inform us about whether and how much global warming can be attributed to the presence of humans, what the implications of those changes are, what specifically should be done to ameliorate adverse changes, or about a host of other sensible-empirical issues that bear on particular policy choices regarding the environment. The Church does not serve as a general source of sensible-empirical knowledge that can guide policy choices through criticizing empirical scientific claims. Nor does the Church have knowledge about how prudently to weigh competing policy options, insofar as these are embedded in different empirical data sets. The Church, however, can join scientists, philosophers of science, and wise policymakers in reminding us about the uncertainty of scientific claims and about the need always to act with prudence and caution. In environmental policy, as with all empirically driven policy choices, there are good grounds for caution with regard to apodictic statements. The role of the Church is to bring us in right worship and right belief through repentance so that we may be purified, illumined by God, and brought into union with Him.

Concerning the environment, and more generally with respect to developing environmental policy, there is uncertainty about all the empirical data that can be invoked to change and frame policy. One might note the extent to which many earlier policy recommendations failed to anticipate the cur-

rent downward trend in population growth throughout the world.[1] Previous secular prophets of the future have at best had a mixed record. This point is multivalent. The uncertainty regarding predictions with respect to the environment reflects not only the uncertainty of all sensible empirical claims but also the special complexity of environmental studies and their attempts to predict the future. Environmental studies must take account, for example, of a wide range of variables, including fluctuations in the amount of energy emitted by the sun. On the face of the complexities and uncertainties involved, one would expect that precise predictions would generally be difficult, if not impossible. The articulation of a concrete environmental ethics must begin with a recognition of the finitude of human sensible empirical knowledge.

Given that all policy recommendations are also shaped by background moral and political commitments,[2] it must also be recognized that policy recommendations depend on the framing of the moral, cultural, and political presuppositions, and on the special agenda of those who commission studies and reports as well as oversee their production and interpretation. The overlay of moral and policy agendas in the framings of scientific findings in the case of reflections on matters ecological is illustrated by what has come to be termed "Climategate," which shaped disputes regarding the possible influence of the agendas of particular scientists and research groups involved in the reporting of findings regarding the environment.[3] When science is tied to a commitment to particular policy objectives, there is a tendency to accept findings as facts that will support one's position regarding the nature of environmental change and thus regarding what counts as prudent environmental public policy. Empirical disagreements are often framed within disparate views of appropriate environmental policy. Reflections regarding the likely future of the environment are nested in controversy.[4] Nevertheless, defenders of particular positions in scientific and policy debates often fail to nest their findings within sufficiently qualifying, cautionary statements. It is in response to the lack of such caution on the part of Albert Gore's statements that his co–Nobel Laureate John Christy remarked that nature "is so complex, and so the uncertainties are great, and then to hear someone [Gore] speak with such certainty and such confidence about what the climate is going to do is—well, I suppose I could be kind and say, it's annoying to me."[5] Scientists, especially applied scientists and advocates of particular policies advanced on the basis of empirical findings, are well advised to nest their claims within qualifications that recognize the uncertainties of empirical knowledge, the complexity of empirical reality, and the possible distorting force of antecedent moral and political commitments.[6]

Against this background of controversy and contention, this essay focuses primarily on what Orthodox Christianity can bring to the articulation of an environmental ethic. To do this, first a general theological background is sketched, then some salient empirical and moral ambiguities are noted, and then finally some general theological constraints and norms bearing on environmental ethics are elaborated. Throughout, the emphasis is on recalling the prime focus of Orthodox theology, which falls on rightly loving, worshipping, and believing in God and, in the light of that rightly ordered love of God, loving one's neighbor. Within these constraints, Orthodox Christianity leaves a considerable space within which one is left to determine prudent choices. The essay concludes with the recognition that we must first pursue the kingdom of heaven, not the realization of the environmentalist kingdom. Only then can we rightly approach the task of caring for the environment, and then likely only through repentance for the ways in which we will always fall short of a rightful dominion over nature.

The Theological Background

In approaching our state of uncertainty about empirically sensible claims, we must note that the core truths of Orthodox Christian theology are generally not propositions about sensible-empirical facts of the matter.[7] The truth about which Orthodox theology is competent is that of God and God's relationship to us as well as to reality in general. Orthodox theology concerns God and His relation to creation and creation's proper relationship to God.[8] As a consequence, Orthodox Christianity provides little clear, direct, and specific guidance regarding a range of environmental issues. Orthodox theology does in general tell us about what it means to love God with all our hearts, souls, and minds and about how rightly to love our neighbor as ourselves. It does this by informing us about what behavior in general to avoid and about that behavior in which we ought to engage, especially about how to live in repentance. One can as a consequence derive some content for environmental ethics from the obligations of humans not to harm other humans or not wantonly to harm animals, but the guidance is unlikely by itself to be enough to supply sufficient concrete content for affirming a particular, concrete, environmental policy as the Orthodox policy. Orthodox Christianity does give some specific guidance about how to relate to our neighbor, such as not to murder, commit abortion, steal, as well as regarding the importance of feeding the poor and forgiving injuries. The difficulty is that, although some alterations of the environment may be instruments of murder and theft, in most cases matters are much more ambiguous. In addition, it is

often unclear what changes in the environment will lead to what kinds of harms or benefits for whom and when.

One may nevertheless be tempted to derive a substantive environmental ethic from Scripture, as from the passage in Genesis (2:15) where God put Adam "in the garden of Eden to work it and to take care of it." One might then attempt to unpack from this circumstance a general but nevertheless content-full environmental ethic. However, matters are much more complicated than such a temptation to ground an environmental ethic might suggest. To begin with, Orthodox Christianity's contemporary, normative relationship to nature is not that of Adam in paradise. It is that of Adam after the Fall—indeed, that of Noah after the Flood (Gen. 9:1–7). A consequence of this state of affairs is that the ways in which great ascetics and monastics have in general lived in relationship with nature cannot directly provide guidance for those living outside of a monastic life. The norms for nonmonastics are different from those that bind monastics. Consider, for example, Canon 51 of the eighty-five Apostolic Canons:

> If any Bishop, or Presbyter, or Deacon, or anyone at all on the sacerdotal list, abstains from marriage, or meat, or wine, not as a matter of mortification, but out of an abhorrence thereof, forgetting that all things are exceedingly good, and that God made man male and female, and blasphemously misrepresenting God's work of creation, either let him mend his ways or let him be deposed from office and expelled from the Church. Let a layman be treated similarly.[9]

The canon indicates that the norms for those who have not taken on the monastic ascetic life are not the norms for life in paradise, where Adam and Eve were vegetarians, nor norms for the quasi-angelic life of the world to come, in which humans will not marry (Matt. 22:30). They are norms for those who live in the world that God blesses for the sons of Noah after the Flood.

Environmental ethics is set first within the condition of Adam after the Fall, when nature is no longer in harmony with man. As God states the matter, "Cursed is the ground because of you; through painful toil you will eat of it all the days of your life. It will produce thorns and thistles for you . . ." (Gen. 3:17–18). However, and crucially, as already noted, conditions change further when the sons of Noah after the Flood are no longer vegetarians and are blessed to kill and eat animals. The contemporary normative relationship of humans to nature is not the special relationship of Adam in the Garden of Eden, although the paradigmatic relationship of men to the world has never simply been that of a gardener. After all, the blessing upon Adam and Eve

when God creates them extends beyond just gardening. Adam and Eve are called to

> "Be fruitful and increase in number; fill the earth and subdue it. Rule over the fish of the sea and the birds of the air and over every living creature that moves on the ground." [In this passage] God said, "I give you every seed-bearing plant on the face of the whole earth and every tree that has fruit with seed in it. They will be yours for food. And to all the beasts of the earth and all the birds of the air and all the creatures that move on the ground—everything that has the breath of life in it—I give every green plant for food." And it was so. (Gen. 1:28–30)

Even before the flood, man is to subdue the earth and to fill it with humans, such that man is implicitly blessed to change the environment through his presence. This commission is expanded after the Flood. After the Flood, the authority of man was robustly amplified: he was given a new relationship with nature, for God blesses Noah and his sons by declaring, "The fear and dread of you will fall upon all the beasts of the earth and all the birds of the air, upon every creature that moves along the ground, and upon all the fish of the sea; they are given into your hands. Everything that lives and moves will be food for you. Just as I gave you the green plants, I now give you everything" (Gen. 9:2–3). The sons of Noah are no longer the gardeners of plants but the hunters and consumers of animals. The relation of the sons of Noah to nature in comparison to that of Adam and Eve in Paradise is one of robust dominion. St. John Chrysostom in his commentary describes this relationship as one of "control, authority, and enjoyment."[10] The dominion of Noah and his sons is surely a dominion set within the restraints of particular obligations, but it is a substantial dominion nonetheless. The question is the substance and content of this dominion and the character of the constraining obligations that limit and direct that dominion.[11]

In exploring how to think about obligations regarding the environment in light of Orthodox Christian theological insights about the authority and obligations of the sons of Noah, one must bear in mind that Orthodox Christianity is focused first and foremost on orienting us rightly to God and to love of our fellow man and only at best secondarily on preserving the environment as we now find it. Background to the reflections in this essay is the widespread but not universal secular view that significant environmental changes are occurring consequent upon various forms of pollution and environmental pressures attributable to the presence of humans.[12] For the purpose of this paper, this view regarding environmental change is taken for

granted. Nevertheless, as with all empirical matters, as already noted, there are controversies about what exactly is transpiring, about the implications of what is occurring, whatever that may be, and about what interventions are merited in response to what is taking place, whatever that may be. This paper locates considerations regarding the environment within the context of what Orthodox Christianity knows as well as within what it means prudently to choose among policy alternatives when those alternatives depend on findings that have a heavy political and moral overlay. In locating the challenge of making prudent empirical and moral decisions regarding the environment within the insights of Orthodox Christian theology, one must not lose sight of the circumstance that one is not called to love the environment as we now find it with all one's heart, nor to love this environment as one is called to love one's neighbor.

Environmental Ethics and Environmental Policy: A Brief Review of Some of the Challenges

Cardinal ambiguities beset the articulation of an environmental ethics and the justification of a defensible and appropriate environmental policy, even when ethics and policy are informed by Orthodox Christian theology. First, choices regarding environmental policy generally fall in an area that does not benefit from concrete theological guidance. There is no set of right- or wrong-making conditions embedded in Orthodox Christian theology that would per se forbid particular uses of nature apart from prohibitions such as against bestiality (Lev. 18:23, 20:15–16), the profligate wasting of resources, causing pain to animals without sufficient reason, as well as injunctions to care for one's animals (Deut. 25:24, Prov. 12:10), etc. Humans for centuries have felled forests to plant fields, built canals to divert rivers, and used wood and coal to warm their houses (thus polluting the air of cities), all without remonstrations from the Church. Even God Himself cleared the land of Israel from wild beasts (Lev. 26:6). People have likely always recognized that such undertakings involve tradeoffs between costs and benefits flowing from different changes to the environment. There are no clear standards in Orthodox Christianity or in the resources of secular moral philosophy to determine how precisely one ought to compare possible costs and benefits flowing from different changes to the environment. For example, more productive fields have always meant fewer virgin forests and untilled plains. Orthodox Christianity's concerns for the welfare of man have always trumped concerns to keep nature as it was before humans entered. There appears to be no precise formula for determining how one should balance

an interest in the welfare of humans with an interest in keeping some virgin forest.

Beyond the question of how to balance changing the environment in order to benefit humans with keeping some wilderness areas somewhat as specially protected large-scale parks (for example, as wilderness areas), there is the question of how to balance obligations to humans with interests in preserving particular species. For example, is it clearly sinful to ban DDT in order to avoid risks to animals such as to condors, knowing that this will most likely lead to the death of millions of children in malaria-infested parts of the world?[13] On the face of it, the consideration would appear to go strongly in favor of children and against the welfare of condors. But is it necessarily clearly sinful to ban DDT? The answer may not be fully clear. However, since there are no overriding obligations to the environment as there are strong obligations to aid poor children, an environmental ethic must prefer children to condors.

Aside from a few instances, Orthodox Christian theology appears devoid of a basis for definitively resolving most disputes about how appropriately to compare many of the costs and benefits to humans associated with different policy approaches to environmental change. How should one compare harms and benefits, and for whom? For example, there is the challenge of determining how one ought to compare the loss of agricultural productivity in one area of the world (presuming compensation to the landowners) with an increase in agricultural productivity in other parts of the world, especially when such changes are combined with a general decrease in poverty in the world. Such disputes, like most policy disputes regarding the engagement of science and technology where there is a significant moral and political overlay, involve competing accounts about how responsibly to compare different costs and benefits as well as how prudently to act in a circumstance of epistemic uncertainty. Orthodox Christianity does not give concrete guidance about how to make such empirical determinations in environmental science, environmental policy, or for that matter regarding ordinary medical treatment (for example, about exactly how certain one ought to be, as an Orthodox Christian physician, about a diagnosis before initiating a particular treatment). Within certain general constraints, Orthodox Christianity does not advise us on how to rank values and harms in the composition of an account of human flourishing, as is illustrated by the diversity of the lives lived by Orthodox saints: great hermits, holy emperors, fools for Christ's sake, ascetic patriarchs, and holy warriors.

This general point requires special emphasis. Many controversies in environmental ethics combine controversies concerning empirical assessments of

the probability, extent, and character of harms and benefits associated with particular forms of environmental change with unclarities regarding the probability, extent, and character of the benefits and harms associated with interventions directed to ameliorating adverse environmental changes. Such determinations always depend on empirical circumstances. Policies established on their basis often lead to unanticipated outcomes. For example, consider the question of whether the putatively environmentally friendly policy of diluting gasoline with ethanol on balance benefits or harms persons, or for that matter the environment, whatever "benefit or harm to the environment" might mean apart from reference to man. Any answer is difficult because one must consider the impact on the poor from driving up corn prices, which increases result from the use of corn in the production of ethanol, versus any benefit attributable to decreasing the use of traditional gasoline. As the demand for corn for ethanol production increases, the cost of many basic food staples increases, likely leading in some circumstances to increased marginal death rates. Moreover, agricultural patterns are also changed because of growing more corn, leading to further environmental consequences.[14] Even the establishment of recycling programs cannot be presumed innocent of unintended adverse environmental consequences; for example, the establishment of recycling programs involves more truck-producing exhaust fumes because of picking up and delivering recyclables.

The force of these reflections is that hasty, inadequately considered attempts to address environmental problems, like hasty medical attempts to address the suffering of patients, often cause more harms than benefits. If one simply rushes to "do something" to aid a patient in distress before one is sufficiently clear about the diagnosis and about what treatment will achieve more benefit than harm, one is likely to affect the patient adversely. The challenge is that one must compare the various consequences of deciding to intervene with a particular "proenvironment" policy versus the various consequences of deciding not to intervene. Uncertainties regarding outcomes, as well as unclarities about the proper balancing of risks and benefits to different persons involved in competing policy options, make the nature of appropriate choices in areas of such empirical uncertainty not only difficult but often highly controversial. There is no bright line from Orthodox theology showing how one ought a priori to compare the benefits and harms at stake, let alone frame a concrete environmental policy.

The case of ethanol-enriched gasoline and its impact on the poor illustrates a major challenge. There is always the problem of determining who is helped or harmed, in what way, and how much by environmental changes. Just as the choice to use aspirin to control pain will entail the consequence

that some will die of untoward outcomes from this therapy, so, too, any environmental policy will help some and harm others. Global warming, for example, will be of benefit to some populations while it will harm others.[15] One must take into consideration and compare the likelihood and character of the effects of global warming on rising sea levels, for instance, with respect to morbidity and mortality outcomes for particular populations that do not move from high-risk areas versus the morbidity and mortality risks to the poor elsewhere without further industrial development (not to mention the benefit for some areas of having longer growing seasons). One must take into consideration that the poor cannot quit poverty without economic development and that risks to the poor may be associated with constraints on the world economy from environment-friendly regulations. That is, one must consider what impact exacting more regulations against environmental pollution will likely have on the poor in different areas of the world in comparison to the possible harms from environmental changes. Poverty, after all, is a clear predictor of increased morbidity and mortality.[16] In this regard, one must be careful in developing global critiques of our contemporary consumer culture, in that any abrupt departure from our current consumer culture will likely have an adverse impact on the status of the poor.[17] The problem is how to decide which populations will be at risk, to what extent, and for what harms as a result of imposing or not imposing new, putatively environment-friendly policies. Orthodox theology does not provide clear guidance about how to determine whom to benefit or harm through environmental policy choices.

The challenges are further compounded by the difficulty of having to compare benefits and harms to current generations with benefits and harms to future generations. As one attempts to assess harms to future generations from not intervening to slow global warming, one must determine how to discount those possible harms, given the opacity of the future. The choice of a discount rate with respect to future harms will surely be controversial but nonetheless necessary. Among other things, one can never make predictions of future occurrences with absolute certainty. One must instead weight a future occurrence at something less than 100 percent of its full positive or negative value. Indeed, one must discount the significance of future harms by some percent for every year in the future its occurrence is thought to lie. In making such assessments, one will need to ask whether it will help those in the future more if one invests in technologies to counteract the warming attributable to pollution rather than to limit pollution directly. That is, one will need to consider and critically to compare diverse ways of responding to the challenges from an environment that is changing because of global

warming. One approach is to devise various interventions that will lower the amount of pollutants that are held to be causing global warming, either by changing technology so as to produce less of the harmful pollutants or instead by developing technologies to remove those pollutants from the air.[18] Quite another approach is to engage in technological interventions in the environment in order to counterbalance the causes of global warming.[19] Since an important concern for Orthodox Christians is caring for the poor, one will need properly to discount possible benefits to future generations in order appropriately to take into account how advantaging future generations may disadvantage the current poor by slowing technological development. One will need in particular to assess which current environment-polluting technologies tend to decrease poverty and by decreasing poverty decrease morbidity and mortality risks among the poor.

What We Do Know as Orthodox Christians That Is Relevant to Environmental Ethics

There are important exceptions to the limited ability of Orthodox theology to give substantive moral guidance regarding the fashioning of actual environmental policy in response to ecological changes. At least six observations can establish some side constraints on environmental policy choices in terms of recognizing that an acceptable environmental ethic must affirm the presence of man and come to terms with the consequences that man's presence brings. In particular, an Orthodox Christian environmental ethic must relativize concerns for the environment so that love of the environment does not diminish or overshadow love for God and man. Theological considerations must nest environmental concerns within broader and normatively prior concerns about obligations to God and man. An authentic Orthodox Christian environmental ethic will have a character quite different from that framed by the heterodox and by the secular. Most particularly, an Orthodox Christian environmental ethic will exclude Deep Ecological commitments that bring into question man's dominion over nature or regard negatively the imprint of man's presence on the environment.

First, there is scriptural basis for recognizing that the environment has properly and rightly been changed by humans as a result of obeying the Divine injunction to increase, multiply, and fill the earth (Gen. 1:28). In assessing the relation of humans to the environment, one must begin with acknowledging that there is a fundamental appropriateness to those environmental and ecological changes consequent on the very presence of large human populations. The ecological systems of the world will never be the same,

given the presence of humans, and this is in itself neither wrong nor bad. This state of affairs, as has already been observed, is at least indirectly blessed by God in the command "God blessed them and said to them, 'be fruitful and increase in number; fill the earth and subdue it; and have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the air and over every living thing that moves upon the earth'" (Gen. 1:28), and then again "be fruitful and increase in number and fill the earth" (Gen. 9:1), and then again "be fruitful and increase in number and multiply on the earth and increase upon it" (Gen. 9:7). The world with its ecological systems absent man cannot be the norm for the proper state of the environment and its ecological systems. Rather, the norm is the world with its ecological systems altered because of the presence and dominion of man, especially the dominion of the sons of Noah. All else being equal, it is good that the environment be altered for the benefit of man's presence. Environmentalist concerns for ecological systems that do not recognize this appropriate man-centeredness in environmental ethics are fundamentally perverse.

Second, there is a strong obligation not to transform one's environmental concerns into an all-consuming project. What St. Basil says in warning concerning all-consuming uses of medicine engaged to prolong life also applies to all-consuming concerns to preserve the environment with its ecological systems as we currently find them. St. Basil forbids "whatever requires an undue amount of thought or trouble or involves a large expenditure of effort and causes our whole life to revolve, as it were, around solicitude for the flesh."[20] An all-consuming engagement in environmentalism occurs when one becomes more invested in maintaining the environment with its ecological systems as we now find them than with discharging the two great commandments to love God and love one's neighbor (Matt. 2:22–36). These considerations are not advanced as an argument against environmental concerns and interventions when they are clearly aimed at protecting one's neighbor against known or likely risks attributable to environmental changes. It is rather to recognize that there can be a temptation to be more concerned with keeping the environment and ecological systems as we now find them than with worshipping God and with feeding the poor. Even from a secular moral point of view, the attempt to keep the environment with its ecological systems as they now exist, in a world where environments with their ecological systems are always dynamically in flux and are constantly changing, is at the very least a dubious project, if not foundationally misguided. Those who focus overzealously on preserving the environment and its ecological systems as they now exist run the risk of being more concerned for the pursuit of

preserving a very particular environment than for the pursuit of the kingdom of heaven.

Third, it is important to note that the inclination to approach the contemporary environment and its ecological systems as a quasi-idol is often the result of an immanent displacement of transcendent concerns. In such circumstances, the rituals of recycling can become secular substitutes for the ascetic rhythms and commitments of the traditional Christian life. An immanent displacement of proper transcendent concerns occurs when a transcendent moral commitment is recast in favor of an immanent, moral preoccupation, as when the evil of abortion is no longer recognized and instead access to abortion is embraced as a basic human right, even though abortion for sex selection is condemned with quasi-religious zeal. Under such circumstances, one has lost sight of the primary object of moral concern, namely, the prohibition of abortion, which is rooted in a religiously grounded insight, and has substituted instead a prohibition against abortion when undertaken on sexist grounds. The centrality of the prohibition against abortion is lost sight of and obscured, while an at best secondary issue is given central place. Similarly, zeal for the environment can take on a quasi-religious valence, substituting for the pursuit of the kingdom of heaven, as in the case of Deep Ecologists, who want to pursue the preservation of the environment or indeed its restoration as it would have been without the presence of a multitude of humans.[21] Such zeal for the environment, along with a quasi-religious engagement in activities to preserve the current environment, obscures the circumstance that there is no commandment to keep the environment and its ecological systems as they currently exist but that there is an injunction not to harm the poor. The world and its environment have been given to man to populate and thereby change. When the preservation of the current environment with its ecological systems as they now exist becomes an overriding goal pursued as a matter of ultimate concern, then there has been an immanent displacement of transcendent concerns and obligations. The unique commitment and zeal that one ought to show for the pursuit of the kingdom of heaven, for the Creator, is displaced by a concern for creation, for the environmental kingdom of this earth as we now find it. Among the contributions that Orthodox Christianity can make to the better appreciation of environmental ethics and the articulation of appropriate environmental policy is the relativization of interests in the environment in light of the overriding interest one should have in discharging the two great commandments to love God and love one's neighbor (Matt. 2:22–36). A rightly directed focus on God and neighbor can prevent a displacement of transcendent

concerns for God into an inordinate concern for the environment. Such idolization of the environment has its most radical expression in Deep Ecological views that privilege the environment as it would have been in the absence of man.[22]

Fourth, Orthodox Christian theology can remind us that the holiest part of the world is not pristine nature, surely not nature untouched by humans, but where the Orthodox assemble in Liturgy. We worship not primarily in forests (Isaiah 1:29) but in temples made by man. Moreover, God did not take on nature; God became a man. He took on humanity so that men, not nature, can become gods by grace. It is humans who are called to *theosis*, not nature. Nature indeed can be approached by man as an icon, as a window to God. However, nature will not be transformed as man is to be transformed by the uncreated energies of God. The result is that the pagans' worship of nature as sacred has been radically denied by holy saints who cut down groves sacred to pagans[23] and who felled other natural objects revered by the pagans, thus indicating by implication the dangers inherent in some of the dimensions of our contemporary culture's concern to preserve the environment with its ecological systems as they now happen to be. We look not to the restoration of a prehuman wilderness but to a new Earth with a New Jerusalem, the restored holy city (Rev. 21:1–2). The focus is on the holy city.

Fifth, it is crucial that environmentalism not be used to defend distorted preoccupations with self-realization and self-satisfaction. For example, if out of a desire for a comfortable middle-class life, if not a desire for luxury, husbands and wives limit their offspring to two or three children or even less, all under the guise of protecting the environment, even in the face of a general decrease in reproductive rates, a distortion of obligation has occurred. Justifying small families on the basis of environmental concerns, especially in the case of Orthodox, shows a deformation of moral commitment that privileges the environment over the obligation to raise devout Orthodox for the kingdom of God. It is usually much easier to be zealous about the environment than to shoulder the burdens of raising a large family. This point bears most importantly against those who are Orthodox, for surely the world desperately needs the presence of more Orthodox children who can enlarge the presence of the Church and convert an increasingly secular global culture. In the developed world, given the usual obligations to raise Orthodox children, right-believing and right-worshipping Christians rarely have a justification for limiting their families to two or three children. This state of affairs presents itself as an egregious consequence of an ethos of luxury that nevertheless is often cloaked in a supposed commitment to environmentalism.

Finally, the Orthodox Church can help all place their use of the environment, like the use of all that is in the power of humans, within a life of right worship and rightly directed asceticism. When one attempts to live less engaged in the passions and distractions of overconsumption, one must do so out of love first for God and then for man, not simply out of love for the environment. As always, the issue is not merely what one does but how and why one does it. What one does and does not do with regard to the environment must be placed within a life of rightly directed worship, fasting, and almsgiving aimed toward a wholehearted love of God and one's neighbor. All concrete choices will need to be made prudently while prayerfully recognizing that their consequences will always to some extent be unclear and will often unintentionally be harmful to the innocent. Any attempt to articulate an Orthodox Christian environmentalism must be undertaken with humility within an authentically Orthodox way of life. The focus must always be God centered. For instance, the choice to drive on Sunday, even if it is an environment-polluting drive, if it is undertaken to attend church and be able to take Communion, has a character quite different from the same drive undertaken to observe the spectacle of a sports event. The significance of actual choices regarding the environment and the propriety of those choices are usually highly contextually determined. Faced with the ambiguities of this broken world, one is left prayerfully and prudently to choose the best one can.

Remembering What Orthodox Theology Is About: Pursuing First the Kingdom of Heaven, Not the Preservation of the Environment as We Now Find It or as It Was Before Man

This paper's reflections have been directed to locating concerns for the environment within the Orthodox Christian recognition of the priority of God and man over nature. Many of those who direct their energies to the preservation of the environment and its ecological systems as we currently find them do so absent an appreciation of the presence and power of the sovereign God and the dominion over nature He has given to man. They regard the cosmos and the environment as if it all came from nowhere and goes to ultimately nowhere, for no discernable ultimate purpose. Absent a recognition of God, there is also a deprivileging of man and his place in nature. Also, absent a recognition of God as the source and ultimate meaning of all, there is a danger that the environment as we find it will become for many a surrogate god and that environmentalism and environmental ethics will become a

surrogate religion replete with its own secular rituals. Orthodox Christian theology relativizes all worldly commitments, including commitments to the environment, in light of the ultimate source and goal of everything: the Trinity. This is not to discount the Christian obligation to use nature wisely and even to recognize nature as an icon through which we can look and see God. This is not to affirm the profligate wasting of resources or careless harm to the environment. Nevertheless, concerns for the environment must be nested within an all-encompassing commitment to the Orthodox Christian way of life. In the face of empirical uncertainty, Christians are called to act prudently and with faith in a loving God Who is Lord of the environment. As always and as with all human commitment, concerns for the protection of the environmental kingdom of this world must be understood in terms of a rightly directed pursuit of the kingdom of heaven.